

104

Ezekiel

The priest in exile who saw God's glory leave Jerusalem and promised new hearts and dry bones brought to life.

Ezekiel was a priest who lived out his calling far from the temple. Carried to Babylon with King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, he was called five years later in a blazing vision by the river Chebar. For over twenty years he spoke to the exiles. Before Jerusalem fell, he warned that it would not be spared, acting out its siege and not mourning his own wife's death. After the fall his message turned to hope: a true shepherd, a new heart, dry bones rising, and a new temple where God would live among his people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yechezqel</i> , "God strengthens"
Family	A priest, son of Buzi; widowed in the siege (Ezekiel 1:3; 24:18)
Exile	Taken to Babylon with Jehoiachin, c. 597 BC
Home	Tel-abib, by the river Chebar in Babylonia (Ezekiel 3:15)
Ministry	c. 593–571 BC, by his own dates
Key people	The exiled elders; Jehoiachin; Nebuchadnezzar
Main passages	Ezekiel 1–3; 8–11; 18; 24; 34; 36–37; 40–48
New Testament	Not named; often echoed in Revelation

"A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh."

Ezekiel 36:26, KJV

The life of Ezekiel

Dates are approximate (BC). Ezekiel counts his years from the exile of King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, so "the fifth year" is c. 593 BC.

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| c. 597 BC
<i>With
Jehoiachin</i> | ● Carried into exile
Ezekiel is among the captives taken to Babylon and settles at Tel-abib by the river Chebar. <i>2 Kings 24:14–16; Ezekiel 1:2–3; 3:15</i> |
| c. 593 BC
<i>5th year of
exile</i> | ● Called by the river
He sees living creatures, wheels full of eyes and the glory of the Lord on a throne. God gives him a scroll to eat. <i>Ezekiel 1:1–3:15</i> |
| c. 592 BC
<i>6th year</i> | ● Taken to Jerusalem in a vision
The Spirit shows him idols in the temple courts. Then he watches God's glory leave the temple and the city. <i>Ezekiel 8:1–4; 10:18–19; 11:22–24</i> |
| c. 588 BC
<i>9th year</i> | ● The siege begins, and his wife dies
Babylon surrounds Jerusalem. His wife, "the desire of thine eyes," dies, and he is told not to mourn openly. <i>Ezekiel 24:1–2, 15–18</i> |
| c. 585 BC
<i>12th year</i> | ● News of the fall
A survivor arrives: "The city is smitten." God opens Ezekiel's mouth, and his message turns toward hope. <i>Ezekiel 33:21–22</i> |
| c. 573 BC
<i>25th year</i> | ● The vision of a new temple
In vision he is shown a new temple in careful detail and sees the glory of the Lord return and fill it. <i>Ezekiel 40:1–4; 43:1–5</i> |
| c. 571 BC
<i>27th year</i> | ● His last dated word
God promises Egypt to Nebuchadnezzar as wages for Tyre. Scripture does not record Ezekiel's death. <i>Ezekiel 29:17–20</i> |

Key activities

God made Ezekiel "dumb" for a time and opened his mouth when Jerusalem fell (Ezekiel 3:26–27; 33:22). Readers differ on whether he was wholly silent or spoke only God's messages.

- I Saw the glory of God.** By the river Chebar he saw a storm of fire, four living creatures and a throne, and he fell on his face. *Ezekiel 1:4–28*
- 2 Ate the scroll.** God gave him a scroll full of "lamentations, and mourning, and woe," and it tasted "as honey for sweetness." *Ezekiel 2:8–3:3*
- 3 Became a watchman.** God made him responsible to warn the wicked and the righteous alike. *Ezekiel 3:16–21; 33:1–9*
- 4 Acted out the siege.** He drew Jerusalem on a tile and lay on his left side 390 days, his right 40. *Ezekiel 4:1–17*
- 5 Shaved his head.** He burned, cut and scattered his hair in thirds as a sign for the city. *Ezekiel 5:1–4*
- 6 Saw the glory depart.** He watched the glory of the Lord leave the temple for the mountain east of the city. *Ezekiel 10:18–19; 11:22–23*
- 7 Taught personal responsibility.** "The soul that sinneth, it shall die," yet God has no pleasure in anyone's death. *Ezekiel 18:1–4, 30–32*
- 8 Became a living sign.** When his wife died, he did not mourn in public, as a sign of the shock coming to Judah. *Ezekiel 24:15–24*
- 9 Promised a true shepherd.** He condemned selfish leaders and promised "my servant David" over God's sheep. *Ezekiel 34:1–24*
- 10 Preached a new heart.** He promised cleansing water, a new heart and God's own Spirit within his people. *Ezekiel 36:24–28*
- 11 Prophesied to dry bones.** In a valley of bones, he spoke God's word, and breath came into them. *Ezekiel 37:1–14*
- 12 Saw the river from the temple.** Water flowed from the new temple, growing deeper and bringing life wherever it went. *Ezekiel 47:1–12*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ezekiel.

Old Testament

Ezekiel 1:3; 24:24	The only verses naming him: "Ezekiel is unto you a sign"
Ezekiel 1:1	"The thirtieth year": perhaps his age (Numbers 4:3); debated
2 Kings 24:10–16	The deportation of 597 BC that brought him to Babylon
Jeremiah 29:1–7	Jeremiah's letter to the exiles in the same years
Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3	He names Daniel as a model of righteousness
Echo: Jeremiah 31:31–34	The new covenant, like his new heart

New Testament

Echo: John 10:11	"I am the good shepherd" (compare Ezekiel 34)
Echo: John 3:5	"Born of water and of the Spirit" (Ezekiel 36:25–27)
Echo: Revelation 4:6–8; 10:9–10; 22:1–2	Living creatures, scroll, river

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Ezekiel see and hear by the river Chebar before God gave him his task (Ezekiel 1:26–2:3)?
- Understand:* Ezekiel saw God's glory in Babylon, far from the temple. What would that have meant to the exiles?
- Apply:* Ezekiel was a watchman who had to warn people. Is there someone you need to speak to honestly and kindly this week?
- Apply:* The exiles said, "Our bones are dried, and our hope is lost" (Ezekiel 37:11). Where do you need God to breathe new life?